



THE ROAD
TEMPLATES & WORKBOOKS



Scan the code for more workbooks

What To Expect at Sentencing

A calm walkthrough of the day, so nothing catches you off guard.

Sentencing is the day the court decides what happens next. It can feel enormous and unknowable, which makes the fear worse. Knowing the shape of the day takes some of that fear away. This walks you through what usually happens, in order, and how to prepare.

Every court is a little different, and your lawyer knows your judge. Ask them how your specific court runs. This is the general map.

Before the day

- ☐ Your lawyer will likely review a presentence report with you. Read it carefully. Errors in it can affect your sentence, so tell your lawyer about any mistake.
- ☐ Gather and submit character letters through your lawyer, ahead of time.
- ☐ Decide with your lawyer whether you will speak, and prepare what you might say.
- ☐ Arrange support: who comes with you, childcare, time off work, transport.
- ☐ Ask your lawyer what to wear and when to arrive.

How the hearing usually goes

- The judge confirms the case and who is present.
- Any unresolved issues with the presentence report are addressed.
- The prosecution speaks to what sentence it seeks and why.
- Your lawyer presents your mitigation: who you are, your circumstances, your support.
- You may be offered a chance to speak. This is called allocution.
- The judge announces the sentence and explains the terms.

If you speak: allocution

You are usually allowed to address the court directly. You do not have to, and your lawyer will advise you. If you do, brief and genuine beats long and polished.

- Speak to the judge respectfully and simply.
- Take responsibility where it is honest to do so; your lawyer will guide what is wise given your case.
- It is fine to be emotional. It is fine to read from notes.

After the sentence is announced

- ☐ Listen for the exact terms: any custody, supervision, fines, restitution, conditions.
- ☐ If custody is ordered, ask your lawyer about self-surrender versus immediate remand, and about designation.
- ☐ Ask about appeal rights and the deadline, even if you are unsure.

My notes for the day

Date and time: _____

What I want the judge to understand:

Questions for my lawyer:

This workbook is educational and reflects lived and professional experience. It is not legal advice and does not create an attorney-client relationship. Laws and procedures vary by jurisdiction and change over time. For advice about your situation, consult a licensed attorney in your state.

More free tools and guidance: hub.newphysician.org/templates · bustedbythefed.com · whitecollaracademy.com

The Road · Templates & Workbooks